

August 12, 2026

Absolute Total Care (Centene)
Provider Appeals Department

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Stan Steuber (MRN MUSC3600503), Claim MUSC-20260601-2547-2

Patient	Stan Steuber (DOB 1969-05-08)
MRN	MUSC3600503
Member ID / Group	ABS259528514 / GRP-55905
Claim number	MUSC-20260601-2547-2
Date of service	2026-06-01
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$602.13
Denial code	CARC 50 / RARC N115 — These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer.
Appeal deadline	2026-10-16

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health Florence Medical Center submits this first-level appeal on behalf of patient Stan Steuber (MRN: MUSC3600503, Member ID: ABS259528514) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-20260601-2547-2 for a date of service of June 1, 2026. The claim was submitted on June 14, 2026, and denied by Absolute Total Care (Centene) on July 18, 2026, under CARC 50 ("These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer") and RARC N115 ("This decision was based on a Local Coverage Determination (LCD)"), with the accompanying payer remark that "Documentation submitted does not establish that the service was reasonable and necessary for the diagnosis reported." MUSC Health respectfully disagrees with this determination and requests full reversal and payment at the allowed amount of \$344.90.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Mr. Steuber is a 57-year-old male established patient with active diagnoses of hyperlipidemia (E78.5) and obesity (E66.9), currently managed with Simvastatin 10 mg. On June 1, 2026, he presented to MUSC Health Florence Medical Center, an on-campus outpatient hospital facility, for evaluation by rendering provider Daniel R. Okafor, MD (NPI 1558493021). The encounter was billed under CPT 99214, reflecting an office or outpatient visit for an established patient requiring moderate-complexity medical decision-making. The primary diagnosis recorded for the visit was J06.9, acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified. Mr. Steuber's medical history is notable for recurrent episodes of viral sinusitis, with prior occurrences documented in 2011, 2013, and 2018, establishing a pattern of upper respiratory illness in this patient.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial on medical necessity grounds is not supported by the clinical facts of this encounter. An acute upper respiratory infection is a common, symptomatic condition that routinely and appropriately prompts an in-person evaluation by a licensed physician. The presenting complaint — an acute infectious illness — is precisely the type of condition for which an established-patient office visit is both reasonable and necessary. CPT 99214 requires moderate-complexity medical decision-making, which is consistent with evaluating an acute illness in a patient who carries active comorbidities including hyperlipidemia and obesity and who is on ongoing pharmacotherapy. The presence of these chronic conditions increases the clinical complexity of any acute presentation, as the treating physician must assess potential interactions, contraindications, and the impact of the acute illness on the patient's overall health status.

The payer's reliance on RARC N115, citing a Local Coverage Determination, does not override the clinical reality that this visit addressed an acute symptomatic condition in an established patient with a documented history of recurrent upper respiratory illness. The diagnosis of J06.9 is clinically appropriate and consistent with the patient's longitudinal history. MUSC Health maintains that the documentation supports the medical necessity of this service and that the denial reflects an overly restrictive application of coverage criteria to a straightforward, medically indicated encounter. Absolute Total Care's obligation under its provider agreement and applicable Medicaid managed care regulations requires that covered services be evaluated against accepted clinical standards, not denied on the basis of an unsupported assertion that necessity was not established.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Absolute Total Care (Centene) reverse the denial of Claim MUSC-20260601-2547-2 and issue payment at the contracted allowed amount of \$344.90 for CPT 99214 rendered on June 1, 2026. Should the plan require additional clinical documentation from Dr. Okafor's encounter record to complete its review, MUSC Health will provide that documentation promptly upon request. We ask that this appeal be adjudicated no later than the timeframes required under applicable Medicaid managed care appeal regulations. If the plan upholds the denial, we request a written explanation specifying which element of the LCD was not satisfied and the precise documentation deficiency identified, so that any further appeal may be appropriately targeted.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record